

SIDE-SUIT RUFF BEFORE TRUMPS

South opens 1♠, partnership reaches 4♠, South declares.

Teaching feature: declarer has 5 spades opposite 3 in dummy. Dummy has a SINGLETON heart. Declarer's hand has 3+ small hearts (one or more losers). You need to ruff a heart in dummy — but you must do it BEFORE drawing trumps, otherwise dummy's trumps will be gone.

Holdings:

- Spades — AK + 3 small in South opposite Jxx or Qxx in dummy. 5-3 fit.
- Hearts — singleton in dummy, several losers in declarer's hand. The ruff is the only way to dispose of one of declarer's heart losers.
- Diamonds/clubs — split honors.

If you cash AK of trumps first, dummy's small trumps go away. Now you can no longer ruff hearts in dummy. The lesson: WIN THE OPENING LEAD, then take your heart ruff IMMEDIATELY, then return to drawing trumps.

Things to think about:

- Count your losers and trumps before touching them.
- Plan the order of plays before leading to trick 2.
- If trumps split 3-2 it's safe to draw one round before ruffing — but never more.